‘You just play. The cameraman will keep up with you best he can.’

Me and the lads were just in shorts. We’d nothing on our feet to spoil the feel of the sand and the ball and we scuttled, backwards and forwards, taking the ball away from each other. You’d try a little trick and slip a pass to the person nearest you who, for that moment, looked like he might be on your side. There, in the warm breeze of late afternoon, I suddenly felt lifted away. I could have been the father of any one of those boys. Any of them could have been me, a youngster, sweat running down my temples, in the middle of a five-a-side over at Chase Lane Park. They could play a bit, these lads. I realized it was the first time I’d had a game since I got injured against South Africa in Durban. We weren’t doing the bloke with the hand-held camera any favors: we’d forgotten all about him. Lost in the game. Like boys—this boy included—have always been and always will be.

Back at the hotel that night, we ate and went to bed. I guess it was the traveling catching up with me. How long had I slept? Two hours? Three? My eyes opened wide in the darkness. Victoria was fast asleep beside me. I hadn’t been woken by a dream or anything else: I lay still for a moment or two, half expecting I’d just drift off again until morning. It wasn’t as if I was fretting about anything. My body clock had just decided this was time for being awake. No point arguing. I started being able to pick out the room around me. I slipped out from under the mosquito net and went through to the bathroom. I found a bottle of water and padded back, the cool wood floor under my bare feet.

Victoria, I thought, probably didn’t want me to shake her awake for a chat. The television was far enough away from the bed that I thought: *if the sound’s turned down, it won’t disturb her*. I let my hand run across a low sideboard until it settled on the remote. I carefully pulled a chair across the room, up close, a yard or so from the screen. I switched it on and sat back.

That little crack of electricity and then the picture comes swimming up to the surface. As things come into focus on the bright screen in that darkroom on the other side of the world, my mouth drops open. I’m watching this team in an all-white uniform. The others are in red and white stripes. I squint to try and pick out individual players. That’s Luis Figo. This is Real Madrid. And there’s Zidane, stabbing a ten-yard pass into the penalty area, away from the defender, into the path of Ronaldo’s run. The big man’s not even had to break his stride. He doesn’t have to give his first touch a second thought. Because his first touch is a shot from fifteen yards, across the goalkeeper, into the far corner. Roberto Carlos is there, jumping all over him. On the screen the